Lessons in Storytelling Transcript

Now, we will be discussing the lessons how to tell a better story. What is the intended purpose of data visualisation? Finally, you want to convince your audience about some particular argument or insight that you are trying to put across using your visual. It is no more relevant if you just present data, you have to have a compelling story line to your data.

Data does not inspire or it inspires only partially, however the stories that you tell along with your data are far more convincing or far more insightful and are more likely to inspire action. It is important to drive from data to generate insights, from insights to action. This is the objective for any data visualisation exercise.

You try to explore the data, bring in insights, explain them to your audience using a very compelling story that is likely to get them into action. It can be either accepting your line of thought or your the presentation that you made here or make them question further and take even more good business decisions. All these are part of driving action from insights in the data to driving action.

This can happen only if your story is consistent, compelling and inspiring. Now, we will take you about how to do such story building and how to deliver such story building. If you have seen a good movie, the strength of a good movie is in its story and its story strength lies in the screenplay.

How are you ordering scenes? How are you building the narrative and how are you delivering the content that you want to get across? So, like in any story there is an incident, then there is rising action, peak climax and then it beat us into action. So, you have to take care of building such a narrative into your visualisation also. Now, we will look into steps in which you can build a compelling story using data visualisation.

First of all you have to ask the question what is the context? We have discussed this in an earlier class about context, here we will be little more specific. First, you have to ask who are your audience that will be receiving the information presented through your data visual. Second, you have to ask what is that you want your audience to look from the visual? What is the expected action from your audience? You have to be very clear about it, whether you want to consume the information just for ah knowledge purpose or you want them to get into action a business insight or you want them to challenge your position and provide a fresh question on your data.

The reaction that you expect from your audience is what creates the purpose for your context. It is very critical to understand what is that you want your audience to look at from your visual and finally, you have to tell them how to consume the data, whether it will be presentation, whether it will be an email, you have to tell him how will they consume this information. Whether it is through direct presentation live interaction or it is a recorded content in which they are consuming information or is a textual document that they are passing through.

This also becomes important because the form in which the story is being told is very important for carrying its effect. You cannot have the same type of visual in a live presentation versus the visual that is used in a textual manner. Let me explain this a bit.

In a live presentation, you have the latitude to interact with the audience in a real time supposing it is a live interaction, physical interaction and these days through online meetings also there can be questions. In that case, you might have to explain certain pointers right away and you have the space to clarify certain things which might not be very clear in the visual. However, when you do a textual presentation in which there is no person to person interaction, the same visual has to speak for itself or you have to build the story such that the visual stands on its own and you might not be there to provide the context and it should be self evident.

These factors like what form the presentation is being delivered, to whom it is being delivered and how do you expect them to consume this determine the context in which you are trying to tell your story. So, think through these things before designing your visual. And always remember your visualisation is not data centric, it is audience centric.

You are doing visualisation not because you are having data, but you want somebody to consume it. So, always keep this in mind, audience is the centre or pivot on which your visualisations are made. Now, how to do this audience analysis? First and foremost you have to ask what is the key takeaway that you want to give from your visualisation and from the takeaway what do you expect? Do you want them to accept or you are saying this is the state of affairs and people are going to accept it or you are trying to incite some discussion on that.

So, if you are trying to showcase a trend or prove a point or putting forward an evidence, you can use a line chart showing continuity. Following just flat principles people are likely to see the continuous trend and expect this is going to continue, you are trying to prove or support more evidence put forth more evidence on that. But you are unsure of the relationship on the statement that you made you want more insight on that.

You can present the same thing as a scatter plot and ask for more questions and feedback and refine your visualisation or take the feedback and do more data deeper data mining under exploratory analysis. And in this way you are able to try to interact with your audience with a clear purpose. Now it is as important as designing the context you should also choose the right visual for communicating your message.

If you choose the wrong visual you might end up communicating sub optimally or you might not get the appropriate acceptance from your audience resulting in insufficient communication of the information or inefficient communication of the information which are not desirable. So, you have to choose the right visual for example, you want to compare you can take a bar graph you want to explore a relationship you can take a scatter plot or you want to show a continuous variable you can take the line chart and these things are best done with the right visuals. If you choose the wrong visuals you might end up unintentionally giving wrong information to your audience or imposing wrong assumptions on your audience right.

And it might not be your intention to do so, but if you do not take care of the right visual or if you do not choose the right visual you might end up communicating sub optimally. Second part of this is to not to create unnecessary complications in your visual like using 3D effects or cluttering the axis providing excessive detail these things have to be avoided and refined in an iterative process so, that the best visualisation is presented. And always remember keeping it simple effectively communicates a lot of information than complicating the visual . So, just these are the common types of charts that you have you have a bubble chart pie chart and these days you have gauges to indicate the ah performance of the companies especially in dashboards.

Then you have ah area chart doughnuts we will be seeing couple of examples in other classes or in experiential learning sessions, but you have to spend sufficient amount of time to understand which chart is used for which purpose and get your hands ah get your ah experience on using those charts. And as I said in earlier as you have learnt in earlier classes there are couple of visualisations a dozen of them which are used in almost all 95 percent of the cases. So, if you are thorough with what is the purpose of the chart and which situation it is best used and how to use it best you would be building very effective visualisations.

Once you have the visualisations you can use additional elements to improve your story. One of the main elements that you can use to improve your story is visual hierarchy. Visual hierarchy is like creating elements within your data visualisation space to bring more impact and meaning.

If you recall we have seen an example where the skater plot has the additional imposed categories of low issues and high issues for car users depending upon the number of issues. Like way in any graph you can try to put more hierarchies and get visual elements into the graph that can provide better context explanation improve accessibility and make it easily interpretable for your audience. In this way not only the story gets conveyed it gets conveyed effectively and easily bringing more acceptance to your visualisation.

Remember one should not overdo these elements that can destroy the original purpose. You have to use them as much as possible only to help you to tell your story in a more effective manner. If it is not helpful do not add these elements only consider them adding if they are supporting your case.

We will see in our next classes how pre-attentive attributes like colour, shape and the size can be used to bring more meaning to your graphics and just let principles are your guiding force all through this course to understand how to build effective visuals. They are very simple principles, but have profound impact in creating perception and centering the focus of your audience. Again to summarise buildings data visualisations is not just sufficient you should tell a compelling story accompanying the visualisations to help people build better narratives and absorb the content that is there in your visualisations.

The end goal is to drive people to action from data insights that can be done only if your story is compelling and inspiring to them. You have to follow certain steps in building a compelling story like taking care of ah the context of the story, building it very clearly to whom you are catering to trying to choose the right visual and finally, using visual hierarchies and other pre attributes to make your story easily conveyable. So, you can use these principles and build a good storyline and convey your effect visuals in a more effective manner.

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